

11. Information on Occupied Housing Units

This Chapter discusses detailed information on the occupancy, structure, and condition of housing units. Furthermore, it examines household data related to main source of drinking water, energy sources used for daily essentials such as cooking and lighting, and sanitation facilities including toilet usage. Additionally, the chapter covers household waste disposal methods, as well as the availability of communication technology equipment and vehicles.

11.1 Concepts and Definitions

Single housing unit

Housing units that have independent walls not connected to any other housing unit or building vertically or horizontally, are called 'single housing units'.

Attached housing unit.

If two or more housing units are attached to each other, either horizontally or vertically, each of those units is considered an attached housing unit.

11.2 Introduction

During the listing stage of the Census of Population and Housing – 2024 all buildings were listed and classified into four categories as housing units, collective living quarters, residential institutes, and non-residential units. Then at the enumeration stage, in addition to collecting the population data, information regarding occupied housing units was also collected. Also, data regarding housing units has been collected in every subsequent census after 1971. The information gathered during the current census, along with the relevant data analysis, is presented at the district level and categorized by sector namely: Urban, Estate-Urban, Rural, and Estate-Rural.

During the collection of housing data, information specific to housing units (such as occupancy, structure, ownership, condition of units, construction materials, and number of rooms) was gathered at the housing unit level. Concurrently, information regarding the living conditions within those units (including water supply, cooking fuel, lighting, sanitation, and waste disposal) was collected at the household level.

11.3 Residence, structure, ownership

Occupancy of housing units

The Table 11.1 shows the number of occupied housing units by sector as reported in the 2012 and 2024 Censuses.

Table 11.1 : Number of Occupied Housing Units by Sector, 2012 and 2024

Sector	Occupied housing units	
	2012	2024
Sri Lanka	5,207,740	6,030,541
Urban*	891,103	1,028,363
Rural	4,092,252	4,773,336
Estate-Rural**	224,385	228,842

*Although the 2024 Census collected information separately as urban and estate urban, here the two categories are combined and shown as urban.

** The sector identified as 'Estate' in the 2012 Census corresponds to the 'Estate Rural' category in the 2024 Census.

The table shows an overall increase in occupied housing units in Sri Lanka from 5,207,740 in 2012 to 6,030,541 in 2024, indicating a substantial growth in housing across the country. This upward trend is observed in all sectors.